

AI for Homework: Parent Guide

Supporting Learning Without Doing the Work for Them

The Parent's Dilemma

You want to help your child with homework, but:

- You don't remember the maths you learned years ago
- You're unsure how they're being taught now
- You want them to learn, not just get answers
- You're worried about them using AI to cheat

This guide will help you use AI as a learning tool, not a shortcut.

The Golden Rule

| *AI explains HOW, children do the WORK.*

AI should be like a tutor who guides understanding, not a service that does homework for them.

What's Allowed vs. Cheating

 **ALLOWED - Using AI to Learn:**

Understanding Concepts:

- "Explain photosynthesis in simple terms"
- "What does 'metaphor' mean with examples?"
- "How do I solve fractions with different denominators?"

Getting Unstuck:

- "I don't understand this step in my maths problem. Can you explain the process?"
- "What's a good way to start an essay about Shakespeare?"

Checking Work:

- "Is my understanding of this concept correct?"
 - "Does my essay structure make sense?"
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NOT ALLOWED - Cheating:

Having AI Do the Work:

- "Write my essay about World War 2"
- "Solve these 10 maths problems for me"
- "Give me the answers to these questions"

Copying Without Understanding:

- Copy-pasting AI responses
 - Using AI words without comprehension
 - Submitting AI work as their own
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How to Use AI for Different Subjects

Maths

Good Prompts:

"Explain how to multiply fractions using an example"

"What's the process for solving $2x + 5 = 13$?"

"Why do we need to find a common denominator?"

Your Role:

- Have them explain the method back to you

- Watch them solve similar problems
- Ensure they understand, don't just copy steps

Red Flag: They get the right answer but can't explain how

English / Reading

Good Prompts:

"What are the main themes in [book title]?"

"Help me understand what this poem means"

"What's the difference between a simile and metaphor?"

Your Role:

- Discuss the concepts together
- Ask them what they think
- Have them write in their own words

Red Flag: Their writing style suddenly changes drastically

Science

Good Prompts:

"Explain the water cycle like I'm 10 years old"

"What's the difference between acids and bases?"

"Help me understand how plants make food"

Your Role:

- Ask them to explain it back
- Connect to real-world examples
- Do hands-on activities when possible

Red Flag: They can't answer basic questions about the topic

History / Geography

Good Prompts:

"Why did World War 1 start? Explain the main causes"

"What's the climate like in rainforests and why?"

"Who was [historical figure] and what did they do?"

Your Role:

- Verify facts with reputable sources
- Discuss different perspectives
- Encourage critical thinking

Red Flag: Information that sounds too detailed or perfect

The Learning Conversation Method

Use this approach for any homework help:

Step 1: Understand the Question

- "What is your homework asking you to do?"
- Make sure they understand what's being asked

Step 2: What They Already Know

- "What do you already know about this topic?"
- Activate prior knowledge

Step 3: Use AI as a Tutor

- Together, ask AI to explain the concept
- Read and discuss the response

Step 4: Check Understanding

- "Can you explain that in your own words?"
- "Why does that work?"

Step 5: Apply It Themselves

- They do the actual work
- You/AI provide hints if stuck, not answers

Step 6: Review Together

- "Does your answer make sense?"
 - "What did you learn?"
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Example: Homework Help Session

Scenario: Year 5 child struggling with fractions homework

Wrong Way:

Parent: "Let me just show you..." (does the problem) Or: "Ask ChatGPT to solve these"

Right Way:

Parent: "What's the first problem?"

Child: "I need to add $\frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{3}$ but they have different denominators"

Parent: "Right. What do you know about adding fractions?"

Child: "They need the same bottom number?"

Parent: "Good! Let's ask AI to explain HOW to find a common denominator."

Together, they ask AI: "Explain how to find a common denominator when adding fractions, using $\frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{3}$ as an example. Don't give me the answer, just explain the method."

AI explains the process

Parent: "OK, can you explain that back to me in your own words?"

Child: *Explains the process*

Parent: "Great! Now you try the problem using that method."

Child: *Works through it*

Parent: "Excellent! Now try the next one on your own."

Red Flags Your Child is Cheating

Watch for these warning signs:

▶ Sudden Perfect Work

- Previously struggled, now everything is perfect
- Vocabulary they wouldn't normally use
- Knowledge beyond what they've been taught

▶ Can't Explain Their Work

- "I don't know, I just found it"
- Can't do similar problems
- Doesn't understand their own answers

▶ Suspicious Behaviour

- Hiding screens when you approach
- Finishing homework unrealistically fast
- Resistant to showing their process

▶ AI-Style Writing

- Overly formal or perfect grammar
 - Advanced vocabulary out of nowhere
 - Generic, essay-like responses
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What to Do If They Cheat

Don't Panic

- It's a learning moment
- Most kids try it at some point
- Handle it calmly

Have the Conversation

Step 1: Private, Calm Discussion "I noticed your homework seems different from your usual work. Can we talk about it?"

Step 2: Listen "Why did you feel you needed to do this?"

- Pressure to perform?
- Didn't understand?
- Saw friends doing it?

Step 3: Explain Why It Matters

- They're only cheating themselves
- Won't learn the material
- Tests will be harder
- Builds bad habits

Step 4: Reset Expectations "Let's do this assignment together properly. I'll help you learn."

Step 5: Create Better Habits

- Set up proper AI use rules
- Regular check-ins
- Supervised homework time (temporary)

Inform the School?

Consider telling if:

- Major assignment or exam
- Pattern of behaviour
- School's academic integrity policy

You can also:

- Help them redo the work properly
 - Learn from the mistake
 - Move forward with better habits
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Setting Up Good Habits

Create a Homework Routine

The Environment:

- Common area, not bedroom
- AI device visible to you
- Regular check-in times

The Process:

1. Read assignment together
2. Discuss what they know
3. Identify what they need to learn
4. Use AI for understanding (together)
5. They do the actual work
6. Review together

The Rules:

- AI for learning, not answers
 - Show your working
 - Explain your thinking
 - Ask for help when stuck
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Age-Appropriate Guidelines

Primary School (Ages 5-11):

- **Always supervised** AI use
- Sit with them during homework

- Simple explanation prompts only
- Focus on understanding concepts
- Lots of hands-on practice

Secondary School (Ages 11-16):

- **Monitored** AI use
- Check in regularly
- Teach proper research skills
- Random spot checks
- They explain their process to you

Sixth Form (Ages 16-18):

- **Guided independence**
 - Open conversations about integrity
 - Teach citation and attribution
 - Trust with verification
 - Prepare for university expectations
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Prompts That Encourage Learning

For Understanding:

- "Explain [concept] in simple terms with an example"
- "What's the difference between [A] and [B]?"
- "Why does [thing] work this way?"

For Stuck Points:

- "I'm stuck on this step: [describe problem]. Can you explain the process without giving me the answer?"
- "What method should I use to solve [type of problem]?"

For Checking:

- "Is my understanding of [concept] correct?"

- "Does this approach make sense for [problem]?"

For Structure:

- "What should I include in an essay about [topic]?"
 - "How do I structure a science report?"
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Working WITH Teachers

Communication is Key:

Tell Teachers:

- Your family uses AI for homework help
- How you're using it (learning vs cheating)
- Ask about their AI policy

Ask Teachers:

- What's allowed and not allowed?
- How can AI support learning?
- What are the school's rules?

If School Has Concerns:

Be Honest:

- "We use AI to explain concepts"
- "I supervise all AI use"
- "Happy to demonstrate our process"

Work Together:

- Follow school guidelines
 - Adjust approach if needed
 - Regular updates on progress
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Building Real Understanding

The "Can They?" Test:

After using AI to help, check if they can:

☐ Explain the concept in their own words ☐ Solve similar problems independently ☐
Teach it to someone else ☐ Remember it the next day ☐ Apply it in different contexts

If NO to any: More learning needed! **If YES to all:** They genuinely understand!

When Your Child Needs More Help

AI can't replace:

✗ Learning difficulties support ✗ Tutoring for ongoing struggles ✗ Teacher feedback
✗ Educational assessments

If they're consistently struggling:

- Talk to their teacher
 - Consider professional tutoring
 - Get learning needs assessed
 - AI is a tool, not a solution
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Quick Reference: AI Homework Dos and Don'ts

DO:

- Use AI to explain concepts
- Discuss AI responses together
- Have them do the actual work
- Check they understand
- Teach critical thinking
- Verify information
- Build on AI explanations

✗ DON'T:

- Let them copy AI answers
 - Use AI unsupervised
 - Skip understanding for speed
 - Accept first response as truth
 - Use AI for entire assignments
 - Ignore school policies
 - Assume AI is always right
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Resources

For Parents:

- **The AI Ark:** theaiark.org
- **Alongside AI Basics:** alongside-ai-basics.netlify.app
- **Common Sense Media:** commonsensemedia.org

For Schools:

- Many schools are developing AI policies
- Ask your school about their guidelines
- Share this guide with teachers

For Help:

- Your child's teacher (first stop!)
 - School learning support team
 - Educational psychologist (if needed)
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Final Thoughts

AI can be a powerful learning tool when used correctly. The key is:

1. **Supervision** - Especially for younger children
2. **Understanding** - Not just answers
3. **Integrity** - Doing their own work

4. **Communication** - Open dialogue about AI use

Your involvement makes all the difference. By teaching them to use AI responsibly now, you're preparing them for a future where AI will be everywhere.

Remember: The goal is learning, not perfect homework!

This guide is provided by The AI Ark Free AI Education for Families theaiark.org